

High-quality texture pack

BioWare has released a high-quality texture pack for Dragon Age II. Download it for better graphics

Upcoming BioWare projects

BioWare's is also involved in Star Wars: The Old Republic, an MMORPG set in the KOTOR era of the Star Wars universe

SKOARI! Review

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Dragon Age: Origins managed to garner some impressive accolades despite numerous flaws and Dragon Age II follows suit by bringing in as many flaws as it fixes. You know, just to keep things balanced.

It is set as a framed narrative; the story of Hawke as told by Varric, a suave dwarf. Hawke (i.e. you) were in the center of events that led to the current crisis in the world, and your companion Varric is being interrogated to understand how things turned out the way they did. He tells of you rise to power over a decade from a refugee to the champion of Kirkwall and beyond.

Varric isn't adverse to exaggerating or lying of your exploits in the story he is telling, a point that is quickly picked up by his future interrogator. In fact the first few minutes of the game tell the legendary version of Hawke's story where his abilities (and his sister's bust size) are greatly exaggerated.

Despite your story being a flashback, you know little of what it is you're supposed to achieve at the end! What happened, and why are you important, such things were clearer in the first game as your role was defined from the beginning.

It works well for the story, as you feel like you are caught in the events instead of someone with a clear mission or goal. This also means that for the most part, you are unaware of where you are heading. You complete quests to move ahead, but each quest seems insignificant as the sum of the parts will only come at the end of the game.

Your companions have a bigger role to play and their stories have relevance to the plot instead of simply being quests to gain approval. Often they are the catalyst for the events that lead to your rise in

power. Rather than hanging around in a "party camp" like zombies waiting for the next apocalypse, they have their own hangouts that you will need to visit occasionally to move forward their story.

The old approval system for companions is gone, replaced by a new friendship / rivalry system that lets you get companion quests even if you aren't the bestest of buds. The system is still imperfect though, as you need to be friendly enough or a big enough rival, since being a neutral friend has fewer benefits.

Dragon Age II now has a skill tree rather than a linear progression of skill. Some skills can be upgraded making them more powerful / less expensive. This has its benefits, but it

does make combat less varied as you'll probably have fewer skills. Despite ending both Dragon Age: Origins and Dragon Age II at level 23, I ended with 30 different usable skills in the former while in the latter it was a mere 13.

Even so, combat is more responsive, and dynamic, a huge improvement over Dragon Age: Origins, which seems like a few 90-year-olds discussing medications in comparison. It still has its flaws though and it is clear BioWare still hasn't figured out the right balance in combat as the game mostly isn't challenging at "Normal" difficulty, yet gets disproportionately tougher during "boss" fights.

When it comes to graphics Dragon Age II is a huge improvement. The graphics and textures are much better, crisper, and less... brown. It holds up well especially for an RPG.

If you were wondering how BioWare managed a full sequel in less than two years while still releasing a string of DLCs and an expansion pack for the first, it becomes clear as you play the game. Firstly, you can only play as a human, mage, warrior or



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rogue with only one origin story. Secondly the game is set in a much smaller location of Kirkwall and surrounding areas. Using a day / night switch the same areas offer different quests. Finally, and most frustratingly, maps have been excessively reused. Every warehouse, and worse, every cave looks the same! With minor changes they have created an illusion of variance that doesn't last.

The game is also much shorter, and will barely push past 50hrs while the first game could easily extend beyond 80 hrs. This isn't a criticism though, it's shorter length doesn't hamper its quality, but merely explains its quick release.

Verdict: Overall Dragon Age II is a great game and a worthy sequel which is let down by poor combat balance, overused locations and numerous bugs — most have been fixed since release. The subject matter Dragon Age II deals with is a lot of what was left out, or glossed over in the first game, now explored with the kind of depth it deserves. The game improves over the first in many ways but brings enough changes and flaws to alienate some of those who loved the first game. **d**

Pros:

- Improved graphics
- More engaging combat
- Better, more involved characters
- Marvelous story

Cons:

- Less variation in maps
- Numerous bugs
- Poor combat balance

Details

Genre: Role Playing Game
Studio: BioWare
Publisher: Electronic Arts
Platforms: Windows, Mac OS, PS3, XBOX 360

